

ALAMY

WESTERN WONDER A tea plantation in Munnar, Kerala

NOT SO ESA

The seventh draft based on the Kasturirangan report proposes 56,825.7 sq. km of Western Ghats as Eco-Sensitive Area (ESA)

KARNATAKA: Highest share of 20,668 sq. km. Rejects draft outright; special assembly session due to take it up. Farmers angry

MAHARASHTRA: Second-highest share—17,340 sq. km. Accepts ESA in principle, but wants 378 villages excluded, a substantial footprint

KERALA: 9,993.7 sq. km. Seeks to cut this to 8,590 sq. km, exclude inhabited areas, farms, plantations

TAMIL NADU: 6,914 sq. km. Ready to sign on, but its mapping faces criticism for excluding vulnerable areas while preserving forests

GOA: 1,461 sq. km. Is broadly on board, but worried. Wants 21 villages in Sattari taluka kept out

GUJARAT: Smallest share—449 sq. km. Has given conditional consent to draft, seeking allowance for minor-mineral mining in non-forest patches within ESA

Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel led by ecologist Madhav Gadgil recommended treating the entire range—then calculated at 129,037 sq. km—as ecologically sensitive, graded into three zones, with the tightest curbs in the most fragile, ESZ-1. It also proposed a statutory Western Ghats Ecology Authority and a bottom-up model of governance rooted in gram sabhas. All six states balked, and said it would choke development and livelihoods.

To defuse the revolt, the Centre in 2013 handed the file to a high-level group under former ISRO chairman K. Kasturirangan, which duly softened it. It split the Ghats into "cultural" and "natural" landscapes and recommended protecting only the natural part—roughly 37 per cent, or about 60,000 sq. km—sparing plantations, farmland and settlements. Every draft since built on that smaller footprint.

The first came in 2014; the sixth draft settled on 56,825.7 sq. km and added a state-wise delimitation of areas. Those are what the states are presently trying to shrink further. Karnataka, handed the largest ESA share of roughly 20,668 sq. km, had rejected the Kasturirangan report. That stance is intact regardless of which party rules. Fractious Kerala, too, manages to find bipartisan opposition to it.

WARNING SIGNS

Ecologists have argued since the first draft that 56,000-odd sq. km is too little, and that each revision has hollowed out Gadgil's design, including the role for gram sabhas that he built to keep decisions local. With every lapsing draft, the pursuit of solutions is getting trickier—and the wait more perilous. The Wayanad landslides of 2024, and the toll wrought by the Kerala floods of 2018-2019, have all been linked to unchecked construction and quarrying on fragile terrain—the very things Gadgil wanted stopped.

"We need a fine balance. Basic developmental and livelihood needs cannot be denied. People must get incentives to conserve biodiversity, some form of green credits," says Raman Sukumar, professor of Ecology, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore. Another conservationist says requisite community-level consultation and ground truthing have not been done. He points to the need to protect "the livelihoods of the 'ecosystem people'—those who use the produce of the forest". The irony: states could cite empathy as a ruse for commercial interests.

In December 2024, the 18th India State of Forest Report offered a deceptively calm picture. Across 2013-23, it said, the Western Ghats had lost only a net 58.22 sq. km of forest cover. The catch: any patch with 10 per cent canopy is counted. In reality, the famous Nilgiris in Tamil Nadu lost 123 sq. km of forest. That's never coming back. ■